

how minor they may seem). This will give you a frame of reference for the condition the apartment needs to be in when you leave. Also, be sure to take pictures after you've moved your things out just in case there's a dispute over any damages.

- **If you plan to renew your lease, contact your landlord two months before the lease is up and try to negotiate.** In an area with an abundance of available rentals, your landlord may agree to keep the rent the same or even to lower it. But don't wait too long to bring up the subject. If you wait until the week before your lease ends, the landlord will assume you're bluffing when you say you're thinking of moving out.
- **Know your rights.** The law protects renters in many ways. Here are a few:
 - » Federal law prohibits a landlord from refusing to rent to you based on your race, sex, religion, disability, national origin, or familial status (meaning whether you're pregnant or have kids under 18). Some cities and states also prohibit housing discrimination based on age, marital status, or sexual orientation. If you think you've been denied housing for any of these reasons, call the Housing Discrimination Hotline at 800-669-9777.
 - » With a fixed lease, such as for one or two years, the landlord is not allowed to raise the rent during the term of the rental contract and must tell you about an impending rent increase before your lease is up. The amount of time within which you must be told of the rent hike varies from state to state. For month-to-month rentals, you must be notified in writing 30 days before the rent is increased.
 - » In some states, if you disobey a provision in your lease and your landlord knows about it but